ONE-OFF SHIURIM

What Will Mashiah Bring?

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 8: redemption, the days of Mashiah
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These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: a collective goal within 6,000 years

The eighth essay is about geulah: Mashiah and the resurrection. Last time the Ramhal taught that Israel is the choicest part of humanity, and that besides each person's individual perfection there is a general tikkun for all of Israel and all of humanity. There were moments in history when we came close, such as Matan Torah, but then came the golden calf. There remains an overarching goal of a perfected world.

God set a limit of 6,000 years for humanity as a whole to reach perfection. Afterwards the world will be renewed in a new form, fitting for eternal enjoyment by those who merit Olam HaBa. As explained in earlier essays, it will be a physical world, but without the physical desires we have now.

Before those 6,000 years end, the chosen nation must reach a state of completion, in which things can be arranged in the pattern of the eternal world. The Rabbi explained that Mashiah is a kind of preparation, a trial run for Olam HaBa. This has been promised and will certainly happen, even if we do not achieve it ourselves. It will come through a descendant of David, chosen by God and given success by Him: the Mashiah, the anointed one.

The Ramhal's utopian picture

In the time of Mashiah and through him, all Israel and all humanity will be rectified. Good will increase and evil will diminish, in matters of the soul and of the body. Our hearts of stone will become hearts of flesh. The Rabbi explained Yirmiyahu's image: stone is what weighs us down, lust, money and the pleasures of this world, and it will become living flesh. Our inclination to do good will grow, and we will not be drawn after material things but will always want to serve God and study Torah. There will be tranquillity and no harm, as Yeshayahu promised. There will be no foolishness, all hearts will be full of wisdom, and Ruah HaKodesh will rest on all people.

He stressed that Ruah HaKodesh here is not prophecy. As learned the week before, it is a much lower level: a deep understanding of the world. "Just reading this is so inspiring. It's beautiful, utopian." Everyone will want to do good, to learn and to understand.

What is the purpose of this time? It gives a taste of Olam HaBa, the real world to come, and it offers one last chance to elevate ourselves before the end.

Choosing between good and better

But this raises a question. We grow by choosing good when we could have chosen bad. If in the days of Mashiah everyone only wants to do good, where is free will, and how can anyone rise "level above level"?

The Rabbi explained that free will remains, similar to Adam's state before the sin. We will only want to do good, but the question will be how much and at what level: good for its own sake, with total self-giving, or less. "It will be a choice between good and amazing." There will no longer be a choice between good and bad, but there will be a choice between good, excellent, outstanding and incredible. Our place in Olam HaBa will reflect those choices.

In its time, or hastened, and the working man

Bringing Mashiah is our collective role, but if we do not succeed, it will happen anyway. The Rabbi quoted the verse "in its time I will hasten it" and the Gemara's explanation: there is a fixed time by which Mashiah must come, and he can also come early depending on how we conduct ourselves and make the world fit for him.

He worked through the numbers. The world as we know it lasts 6,000 years; the seventh millennium is destruction; Olam HaBa follows. In 5782, that leaves at most about 218 years. Since the days of Mashiah must last some period of time, Mashiah would have to come somewhat earlier than the year 6000. How long that period is, he does not know. A participant asked about rebuilding the Temple. The Rabbi said that according to Rashi it will come down from heaven, and according to others we will build it; either way, a matter of months at most. Asked about false messiahs throughout history, he said that is exactly why one should never predict these things.

A participant asked about a man who works at a machine all day for seventy or eighty years with no time for yeshiva. Where does he stand? The Rabbi answered warmly: a person working with integrity, commitment and dedication is doing something incredible. If everyone were honest in business and committed to their work, the world would be transformed. "As long as he does his job properly, that's avodat Hashem." God is the true Judge and takes every circumstance into account, and each person has opportunity on his or her own level.

The Rambam's view

The Rambam paints a very different picture. For him the days of Mashiah will be basically like our own. The Gemara says the only difference between this world and the days of Mashiah is subjugation to the nations. Israel will be sovereign and there will be no wars, but we will still have the same desires and temptations, and still the opportunity to grow. That makes more sense of continued growth, since the possibility of bad remains. But, the Rabbi noted, "we're arguing about a maximum of 217 years."

Everyone must pass through death

The Ramhal then says that everyone, even those alive at the time, must return to the earth, even for a moment, before the resurrection. Then those who merit it will rise. As learned in Part 1, Adam's sin caused a blemish in the physical body that can only be repaired through death: "you are dust, and to dust you shall return." The resurrection rebuilds the body without it.

The details, how Mashiah, the resurrection, the Temple and the war of Gog and Magog fit together, would be covered on Thursday with a timeline.

Summary

- Humanity has 6,000 years to reach perfection; the days of Mashiah are a preparation and taste of Olam HaBa.
- The Ramhal describes a utopia of wisdom, peace and Ruah HaKodesh, with hearts of stone turned to flesh.
- Free will continues, but as a choice between good and better, not good and bad.
- Mashiah can be hastened by our conduct, but must come within the 6,000 years regardless.
- The Rambam sees the days of Mashiah as ordinary life with Jewish sovereignty, and growth still possible.

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